

Eating fruit and seeds

Compared to leaves, fruit and seeds are packed with nutrients, which is why many animals use them as food. In warm parts of the world, fruit grows all year round. Elsewhere, it is seasonal, so animals have to switch to different foods when the yearly harvest comes to an end. Seeds are different, because they often keep for a long time. Animals can either eat them right away or put them in private storage.

Inside job

This weevil grub, peering out of an acorn, grows up inside its food. It eats the acorn as it grows and stays inside it until it falls. Once the acorn hits the ground, the grub crawls out and burrows into the soil. Here, it turns into an adult weevil (a kind of beetle), ready to lay its eggs on acorns the following year. This two-stage life cycle is very common in insects. Many different insects grow inside the seeds of cultivated plants, including cereals, peas, and beans.



Meal on the move

Fruit is the most important item on the orangutan menu. In their natural habitat—the rain forests of Southeast Asia—orangutans eat dozens of species of wild fig, as well as durians, lychees, and rambutans. Each tree fruits at a different time of year and the apes move to follow the pattern of ripening. Fewer fruits ripen during the dry season, so orangutans turn to alternative foods, such as leaves and insects. Some use sticks to get at seeds—a skill they pick up by watching and copying each other. Unlike chimps and gorillas, orangutans spend most of their lives in the treetops and only occasionally come down to the ground.

Final feast

Attracted by its smell, this European hornet is feeding on a ripe fig. During spring and summer, hornets hunt other insects, which they feed to their grubs. As summer comes to an end, there are no more grubs left to feed, and they switch to feeding on fruit. However, this feast is often short-lived. Unlike queen hornets, worker hornets do not hibernate—instead, most of them die with the first frosts.

*Sensitive antenna
detects sugary scents
carried on the air*

